Japan was not the only Asian country with which America attempted to deepen security relations in the light of China's military development. Washington enhanced its security cooperation with Southeast Asian nations, many of which have ongoing territorial disputes with China in the South China Sea. The Obama administration pursued closer ties with Singapore and Malaysia, and negotiated a breakthrough pact with the Philippines to allow US military forces access to bases on the archipelago; this last accomplishment, however, was derailed by the breakdown in relations between Washington and Manila after the electoral victory of Rodrigo Duterte, a populist politician who moved closer to China after criticism by the Obama administration for his supposed support of vigilantes in cracking down on the Philippines' drug trade. And while ties with India during the Obama years did not achieve the warmth of the Bush years, any overtures by Washington to New Delhi were eyed suspiciously by Beijing.

A final element of the Obama administration's pivot to Asia was the negotiating of the Trans-Pacific Partnership, a twelve-nation free-trade pact. Begun in 2005 by Brunei, Chile, New Zealand, and Singapore, the TPP eventually attracted Obama's attention, as well as Japan and America's NAFTA partners, Canada and Mexico. However, the Obama administration did not succeed in getting the pact ratified by the US Senate before its term ended, and the new US president, Donald Trump, withdrew from the agreement after criticizing it during the 2016 campaign (as did his opponent, Hillary Clinton). Despite the lack of implementation, the TPP presented China with the potential of a new free-trade area developing among largely market economies, with high standards for labor and environmental issues that would leave Beijing on the outside. China's response to TPP was to propose a massive new trade network, the One Belt One Road initiative, underpinned by $1 trillion in infrastructure spending across Eurasia and tying together land- and sea-based trading routes with China at the center.

By 2017 and the inauguration of Donald Trump, American strategy in Asia was being questioned as to its coherence, effectiveness, and